Plants and animals that live on or inside other plants or animals are called as *Parasites*. Example; mistletoe lives on other plants. Other examples are tapeworms, round worms, lice, ticks, flea etc.

'*Detritivores*' are consumers that feed on detritus. Detritus includes fallen leaves, parts of dead trees and faecal wastes of animals. Ants, termites, earthworms, millipedes, dung beetle, fiddler crabs and sea cucumbers are detritivores.



The earthworm is called as the friend of the farmer. Find out the reason why?

4. **Decomposers:** Decomposers are organisms that help decompose dead or decaying organisms. Decomposers are also heterotrophs. Decomposers are nature's built-in recycling system. By breaking down materials – decomposers return nutrients to the soil. They, in turn, create another food source for producers within the ecosystem. Mushrooms, yeast, mould, fungi and bacteria are common decomposers.

7.3.2 Food Chain and Food Web

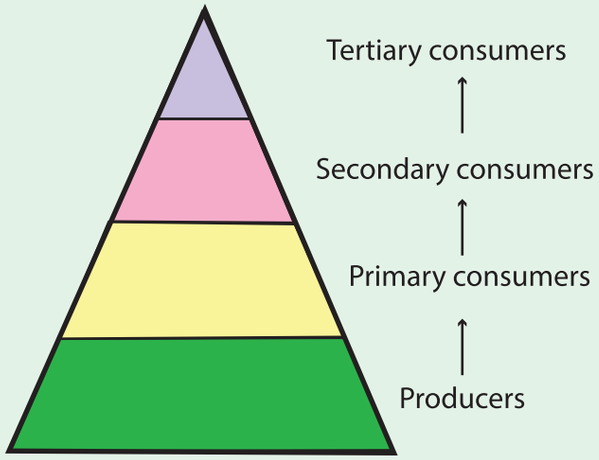
Every living creature in an ecosystem has a role to play. Without producers, the consumers and decomposers would not survive because they would have no food to eat.

Without consumers, the populations of producers and decomposers would grow out of control. And without decomposers, dead producers and consumers would accumulate as wastes and pollute the environment.

All organisms of an ecosystem depend on one another for their survival. Each organism living in an ecosystem plays an important role in the flow of energy within the system. Organisms need energy for respiration, growth, locomotion, and reproduction. This movement of energy is

Student Activity

Give at least two examples for each level.



Trophic level	Example

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